

Climate Action Science Program

Inception Report

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Acronyms

ACIAR	Australian Centre for International Agricultural Research
AGRA	Alliance for a Green Revolution in Africa
AGNES	African Group of Negotiators Expert Support
AI	Artificial intelligence
AICCRA	Accelerating Impacts of CGIAR Climate Research in Africa
AoW	Area of Work
ARBY	Area-based yield index insurance
ARC	Africa Risk Capacity
ARI	Advanced research institutions
AWARE	Early warning, early action, early finance platform
B4T	Breeding for Tomorrow (Program)
BMGF	Gates Foundation
BMWE/IKI	German Federal Ministry for Economic Affairs and Energy, International Climate Initiative
CIAT	International Center for Tropical Agriculture
CIMMYT	International Maize and Wheat Improvement Center
CIS	Climate information services
COP	Conference of the parties
CORDEX	Coordinated Regional Climate Downscaling Experiment
CSICAP	Climate-smart initiatives for climate-change adaptation and sustainability in prioritized agricultural production systems in Colombia
CSO	Civil society organizations
CS-PAT	Climate information services program assessment tool
CWANA	Central and West Asia and North Africa
ESA	East and Southern Africa
EWS	Early warning systems
FAIR	Findable, Accessible, Interoperable, Re-usable
FAO	(The United Nations) Food and Agriculture Organisation
FCDO	Foreign, Commonwealth & Development Office
FLW	Food, land and water (systems)
GCAN	Gender, Climate Change and Nutrition Integration Initiative
GCF/CAF	Green Climate Fund (GCF) / Development bank of Latin America and the Caribbean (CAF)
GESI	Gender equality and social inclusion
GESYI	Gender equity, social, and youth inclusion
GHG	Greenhouse gas
GIS	Geographic information system
HLO	High-level output
IBLI	Index-Based Insurance for Livestock
ICARDA	International Center for Agricultural Research in the Dry Areas
ICRISAT	International Crops Research Institute for the Semi-Arid Tropics
IDA	International Development Association
IFAD	International Fund for Agricultural Development
IFC	International Finance Corporation
iFEED	integrated Future Estimator for Emissions and Diets
IFI	International Finance Institution
IFPRI	International Food Policy Research Institute
IITA	International Institute of Tropical Agriculture
ILRI	International Livestock Research Institute

IPCC	Intergovernmental Panel on Climate Change
IRRI	International Rice Research Institute
ISDC	Independent Science for Development Council
iSPARK	Innovation in Sustainability, Policy, Adaptation and Resilience in Kenya
IWMI	International Water Management Institute
J-PAL	Abdul Latif Jameel Poverty Action Lab
L&D	Loss and damage
LAC	Latin America and the Caribbean
LAPA	Local Adaptation Plan for Action
LLA	locally-led adaptation
LMIC	Low-and middle-income countries
LT-LEDS	Long-term, low-emission, climate-resilient development strategies
MEL(IA)(F)	Monitoring, evaluation, learning and (impact assessment) (Foresight)
MRV	Monitoring, Reporting, and Verification
NAPs	National Adaptation Plans
NDCs	Nationally Determined Contributions
NFCS	National Frameworks for Climate Services
PLACA	Climate Action Platform for Agriculture in Latin America and the Caribbean / La Plataforma de Acción Climática en Agricultura de Latinoamérica y el Caribe
PMU	Program Management Unit
PPU	Portfolio Performance Unit
PRMS	Performance and Results Management System
REMET	Reducing Methane Emissions from Rice project
ROI	Return on investment
S4I	Scaling for Impact (Program)
SA	South Asia
SB	Subsidiary Bodies
SEA	Southeast Asia
SP	Science program
SPIA	Standing Panel on Impact Assessment
TOC	Theory of Change
UNFCCC	United Nations Framework Convention on Climate Change
WCA	West and Central Africa
WCIS	Weather and climate information services
WEFE	water-energy-food-ecosystem
WFP	World Food Programme
WMO	World Meteorological Organisation

Executive summary

The Inception Phase of CGIAR's Climate Action Program (November 2024 - June 2025), marked the transition from design to operational readiness, laying the foundation for the Program to be CGIAR's central mechanism for delivering on its climate ambition. Building on the achievements of prior Initiatives, including ClimBeR, the Climate Impact Platform, Livestock and Climate, Mitigate+, and NEXUS Gains, the Program sharpened its focus on high-potential research and capacity-sharing activities while strategically discontinuing activities with limited scalability, comparative advantage, or partner demand.

The Program was launched at CGIAR Science Week in Nairobi in April of 2025, with a presentation of the five Areas of Work (AoWs) of its scientific agenda: AoW1: Prioritization and Coordination of Climate Action (CGIAR Climate Hub); AoW2: Digital Advisories and Climate Risk Management; AoW3: Locally-led Adaptation; AoW4: Low-emission Transitions; and AoW5: Finance and Policy for Scaling Solutions. The launch also provided a valuable opportunity to integrate feedback from key stakeholders, enhancing the Program's relevance and potential for impact.

Throughout the inception period, the Program emphasized demand-driven co-design by engaging governments, technical agencies, development partners, and civil society through structured consultations. These engagements informed the technical content and partnership architecture, grounding the Program in local realities and strengthening its capacity to deliver scalable, context-responsive climate solutions.

Key design components—including the Program's Theory of Change (ToC); Monitoring, Evaluation, Learning, and Impact Assessment (MELIA) system; and risk framework—were revised in response to ISDC recommendations. Enhancements include clearer articulation of intermediate outcomes, deeper integration of gender equality and social inclusion (GESI), and closer alignment with the Paris Agreement in ways that strengthen country-led climate action. This includes supporting national efforts to pursue low-emissions, climate-resilient development (Article 2), deliver and enhance Nationally Determined Contributions (NDCs) (Article 4), access international cooperation through market and non-market approaches (Article 6), and operationalize the Global Goal on Adaptation (Article 7), in alignment with nationally defined priorities and ambitions.

The knowledge-based prioritization process, guided by the revised ToC, identified key geographies based on climate vulnerability, greenhouse gas (GHG) emissions reduction potential, institutional capacity levels, and stakeholder demand. East and Southern Africa (ESA) and Southeast Asia (SEA) were prioritized for most high-level outputs (HLOs); however, the relevance of specific HLOs varied by region. For example, specific relevant and strategic HLOs for Latin America and the Caribbean (LAC) and Central and West Asia and North Africa (CWANA) were targeted. The prioritization provides a data-point to direct resources allocation where the Program can deliver the greatest impact and where CGIAR's comparative advantage can be most effectively leveraged. At the same time, geographically distributed teams ensure that targeted deliverables contribute to the Program's outputs and outcomes.

The completion of the Inception Phase marks a pivotal transition from planning to delivery. With a refined strategy, prioritized activities, strengthened partnerships, and a more robust operational framework, the Climate Action Program is now positioned to enter full implementation.

1. Program overview

1.1 High-level Vision

The Climate Action Program envisions resilient food, land, and water (FLW) systems across the Global South in the face of climate change, variability, and shocks, operating equitably, and contributing to the removal of global GHG emissions. The Program aims to directly benefit 16 million vulnerable small-scale producers and value chain actors across 30 countries. The Program will build capacity across a wide range of CGIAR initiatives with public, private, and civil society partners to reach over 100 million additional producers. In line with the Paris Agreement, the Program aims to contribute to the reduction, avoidance, or removal of one gigaton of CO₂e, inform at least 100 policies, and influence USD 15 billion in climate finance by 2030.

As CGIAR's climate hub, the Program will guide research priorities, close knowledge gaps, and promote system-wide collaboration through climate analytics, risk data, and alignment of research agendas. Research will focus on climate risk management, digital advisories, locally-led climate action, and low-emission transitions. Policy, finance, and institutional innovations will enable large-scale impact. Solutions include early warning systems; resilient landscapes, agrifood systems and water management; responsible AI-supported analytics; data and tools for improved transparency and reporting; and novel frameworks for carbon removal, methane reduction, and finance to address loss and damage.

Climate change is a multi-faceted challenge that cannot be solved in siloes or with single solutions. By bringing together CGIAR's climate work on adaptation and mitigation under one umbrella, the Climate Action Program will address climate challenges in FLW systems holistically from producer to landscape. It will also identify synergies between adaptation and mitigation and scale innovations across different production systems through policy and finance.

1.2 Achievements from 2022—2024

The Climate Action Program builds on the proven results of four CGIAR Initiatives: ClimBeR, Livestock and Climate, Mitigate+, and NEXUS Gains. Each of these Initiatives delivered high-impact, measurable outcomes aligned with their ToC:

- ClimBeR reached over 2.8 million farmers, informed 45 policy changes, and supported partners to access USD 754 million in climate finance. These outcomes were achieved through over 36 innovations that directly speak to Climate Action's AOWs. ClimBeR's work on digital advisory services through tools like Climate+, CultivateX, and GeoGoviya, and climate risk management bundles such as ShambaShield provide a strong foundation to AoW2. ClimBeR also supported subnational climate risk profiles and dashboards to inform early action. On the policy front (related to AoW5), the integrated Future Estimator for Emissions and Diets (iFEED) helped governments plan for climate-resilient food systems. The progress with these innovations and their use support Climate Action ambition of delivering climate adaptation solutions, policy, and finance at scale.
- Mitigate+ contributed to 4.1 Mt CO₂e in potential emissions reductions and influenced over 25 policies. It co-developed five national strategies using the FOODCLIP framework, launched Living Labs for low-emission innovations, and supported governments in Colombia, Kenya, Vietnam, and China to strengthen Monitoring, Reporting, and Verification (MRV) systems. Digital tools like RiceMoRe and dairy lifecycle assessment methods helped quantify emissions reductions across key sectors. These innovations and partnerships now underpin AoW4 and AoW5 of the Climate Action Program, accelerating implementation of nationally aligned mitigation pathways.

- NEXUS Gains developed decision support tools in river basins, trained stakeholders, and informed 11 policy changes. NEXUS Gains developed decision dashboards and modeling tools that support integrated climate-resilient planning across major transboundary basins, including the Ganges, Nile, and Aral. The Initiative trained women leaders in water-energy-food-ecosystem (WEFE) systems thinking, and co-developed solar irrigation finance models and groundwater recharge solutions.
- Livestock and Climate improved 2.3 million hectares of rangelands, delivered climate services to 1.5 million producers, and supported designing and tracking USD 901 million in finance. Innovations such as the Pioneer Positive Deviance scaling model, rangeland governance toolkits, and livestock-specific climate information services feed directly into AoW2 (digital advisories), AoW3 (locally-led adaptation), and AoW4 (low-emission transitions). The initiative's deep policy engagement, from Kenya to Colombia, now enables the Program to connect delivery with systems change and unlock early impact.

Climate Action consolidates this work into an integrated, system-wide research agenda designed to deliver scalable, demand-driven climate solutions across FLW systems in the Global South. Climate Action also incorporates learning and results from the Climate Impact Platform.

The Program draws on the Initiatives' rich legacy of piloted and validated climate-smart practices, digital tools, and policy frameworks. The new Program leverages these validated approaches and integrates adaptation and mitigation research for broader systems change. Through improved agency approaches and using cutting edge analytics and geotargeting, including AI-enabled digital advisory services as well as MRV systems, the Program is markedly enhancing the reach and relevance of early warning, digital advisory, and decision support systems that were implemented under the Initiatives. Climate Action emphasizes locally-led adaptation, enhancing the capacity of public sector and civil society for improved governance, and co-developed solutions for resilience of agrifood systems.

The new Program aims to formalize and expand this impact by embedding research more directly into investment programs and decision-making processes. Furthermore, the Initiatives began incorporating equity concerns, generated evidence to inform equitable climate policy and finance, and developed gender-equitable climate-related indexes. The new Program mainstreams climate justice, supporting locally-led climate action and just transitions, particularly for vulnerable small-scale producers.

1.3 Description of intended research

What sets Climate Action apart is its ability to integrate adaptation and mitigation within bundled, locally led, context-specific innovations that are ready for scale and investment. While many programs offer fragmented solutions, Climate Action takes a systems approach that combines scientific rigor with inclusive, demand-driven implementation. By prioritizing equity, co-ownership, and regional coordination, the Program positions itself as a trusted platform for delivering transformative climate outcomes across the Global South.

The Program's research agenda is organized into five interlinked AoWs, each responding directly to national priorities and grounded in real-world application. By generating climate analytics and risk insights, AoW1 aligns climate agendas within the Program, across other CGIAR Programs, and among partners. It sets shared priorities and identifies knowledge gaps to inform the design and delivery of impactful action. Building on this foundation, the Program co-designs, develops, and delivers a range of climate adaptation, risk-mitigation (AoW2 and AoW3), and low-emissions (AoW4) solutions. To drive broader systems transformation, the Program informs climate policy and finance that can scale these innovations and institutionalize change (AoW5).

These AoWs reflect where CGIAR and its partners can add the most value—through filling critical knowledge gaps, co-developing tools and methods, and supporting the design and implementation of high-impact climate action. Climate Action’s work is framed by a clear ToC, and every research activity is embedded in multi-stakeholder processes that link local needs with national and global policy frameworks such as NDCs, National Adaptation Plans (NAPs), and the Sharm el-Sheikh joint work on agriculture.

The Program’s integrated model ensures that outputs, whether they be tools, data, finance mechanisms, or policy insights, are immediately usable by partners. This is facilitated through structured engagement mechanisms, coordinated delivery through the Climate Action Hub, and country-level co-design processes. Rather than stand-alone studies, research under Climate Action is designed to shape decisions, scale innovations, and unlock investments across FLW systems.

Below, we provide a concise overview of the AoW-specific research focus, intended outcomes, and methodological approaches.

AoW1: Prioritization and Coordination of Climate Action (CGIAR Climate Hub)

AoW1 strengthens the design, implementation, and impact of CGIAR climate action through coordination and capacity strengthening, improved use of climate data and methods, and synthesis and amplification of CGIAR’s collective climate insights. HLO 1.2 identifies and assesses root causes of climate vulnerability and climate justice pathways. This work combines econometric analyses, spatial analyses, social media and discourse analyses, and community-based participatory research to develop strategies and tools to help mainstream climate justice approaches and thinking within the CGIAR Portfolio.

HLO 1.3 delivers a harmonized data infrastructure for climate impacts and risks and current and future emissions hotspots to support CGIAR and its partners in prioritizing climate action. Research methods include analysis of biophysical and socioeconomic observations, surveys, remote-sensing analytics, climate impact modeling, and scenario-based modeling, with human-centered design approaches informing the shared data infrastructure. HLO 1.4 synthesizes CGIAR climate insights to identify knowledge gaps and share evidence on effective climate interventions and metrics. This will be done using systematic reviews and meta-analyses, integrating novel- and responsible-AI and data science tools to develop living syntheses.

HLO 1.1 and 1.5 deliver the coordination, partnerships, communication strategies, and policy engagement to enable system-wide climate-sensitive programming and amplify CGIAR’s work so as to better inform national to global climate strategies and investments. While these are not research activities per se, qualitative impact assessment studies will be used to monitor and improve the effectiveness of these approaches.

AoW2: Digital Advisories and Climate Risk Management

AoW2’s research targets human-centric, actionable, equity-focused innovation to bridge the gap between climate science and farmer decision-making and livelihood protection programs. Towards this aim it investigates how digital climate information services (CIS), early warning systems (EWS), and climate risk management strategies can equitably improve the resilience and wellbeing of small-scale producers. Its research is guided by four core questions: (1) the effectiveness and sustainability of bundled CIS in meeting the differentiated needs of women and men; (2) how anticipatory action and EWS can overcome gaps in coordination, dissemination, and trust to protect vulnerable communities; (3) how governance innovations can enhance equity in water

resource access under climate stress; and (4) how national climate service frameworks can evolve to address compound risks and deliver measurable resilience outcomes. These questions reflect a commitment to translating climate science into actionable, inclusive, and scalable solutions for rural communities facing growing climate volatility.

HLO 2.1 focuses on delivering contextualized CIS and bundled digital advisory systems. The aim is to reach 10 million farmers by 2030 through a tiered approach targeting farmer reach (e.g., SMS, chatbots, radio, TV programs) and deeper inclusive engagement models that strengthen last-mile advisory delivery. The CIS program assessment tool (CS-PAT) will help us understand opportunities and operational gaps in climate services. To advance delivery, generative AI-powered advisories will enhance tools like GeoAgro, AClimate, GeoGoviya, and Climate+ (amongst others) to deliver inclusive tailored advisories, bundled with management options, and financial solutions (e.g., Index-Based Insurance for Livestock –IBLI, and area-based yield insurance –ARBY). The focus on WCIS is complemented with in-depth work that advances adaptive EWS in at least 20 countries, with an emphasis on fragile regions (HLO 2.2), and aiming to enhance pre-emptive responses (e.g., cash transfers, food aid). Key innovations include compound risk modeling to predict cascading risks (e.g., drought and conflict in East Africa) and multi-hazard early warning systems for crops and livestock. Implementation of HLO 2.1 and 2.2 leverages actions and technologies under the Sustainable Farming and Sustainable Animal and Aquatic Foods Programs, whereas interactions with Scaling for Impact (S4I) are critical for scaling pathway design, deployment, and learning.

The HLOs described above integrate with HLO 2.3 (water resilience) and HLO 2.4 (integrated risk management strategies). HLO 2.3 seeks to address the critical need to co-develop actionable, science-based strategies that integrate water management, food security, and climate resilience. Integrated modeling frameworks, multi-scale decision support, scenario planning, and water accounting tools will generate insights to inform real-time water governance and long-term resilience planning. HLO 2.4 will ensure convergence across all evidence generated in HLOs 2.1–2.3 to scale nationally owned integrated climate-risk management frameworks aligned with World Meteorological Organisation’s (WMO’s) Global and National Frameworks for Climate Services (NFCS).

AoW3: Locally-led Adaptation

AoW3 drives inclusive, equitable, and locally-led adaptation (LLA) to strengthen the agency and resilience of vulnerable communities facing escalating climate risks. Anchored in human-centric, participatory, and place-based approaches, AoW3 research focuses on transforming institutional approaches to governance and development of technical innovations towards co-creation and empowerment of local actors. LLA is a way of doing ‘business unusual’ to ensure voice for women, youth, and Indigenous peoples shape and scale adaptation solutions. Integration of these approaches into public and civic society’s climate action is key to achieving resilience that meets the needs and the vision of communities.

HLO 3.1 focuses on co-designing and deploying adaptation “champions” and community-driven governance platforms that connect science, social protection, and climate services. To achieve largescale impact, this HLO will integrate locally-led approaches working closely with NARES, farmer organizations, and civil society. Activities will include rollout of adaptation marketplaces, establishing multi-functional climate hubs, and participatory foresight to enhance risk-informed decision-making.

HLO 3.2 focuses on avoiding maladaptation and promoting gender equity, social, and youth inclusion (GESYI) through replication of proven LLA models across at least 15 countries. To reach scale while ensuring local relevance and GESYI principles, AoW3 is working with S4I on frameworks

such as living labs that integrate GESYI into climate planning and climate solutions. This collaboration will also involve capacity building to promote broad use. Working with Multifunctional Landscapes living lab initiatives, AoW3 is synthesizing best practices for GESYI aware approaches, and exploring the effectiveness of mechanisms to bundle adaptation with GHG mitigation, ecosystem protection, food security, and financial inclusion. Participatory scenario planning, inclusive metrics of resilience, FAIR data generation, and innovation portfolios will be used to identify priority investments and institutional pathways.

The AoW3 portfolio includes testing and scaling of climate adaptation solutions in collaboration with Scaling for Impact and other Programs, supported by partnerships with national and subnational governments, CSOs, and private-sector actors. Through participatory action research approaches implemented at living labs sites, AoW3 will support community adaptation and a set of solutions space that will provide options for comparable socioeconomic and environmental contexts. These solutions will generate evidence of what works, where, and for whom, contributing to adaptive learning loops and global learning agendas. Insights will directly inform NAPs, local climate action strategies, and operational linkages to climate finance facilities.

AoW4: Low-emission Transitions

To support low-emission transitions in FLW systems, Climate Action will use a mix of interdisciplinary, participatory, and data-driven research methods tailored to LMIC contexts. A transdisciplinary action research approach will involve stakeholders—smallholders, policymakers, and private sector actors—in co-developing, testing and scaling solutions. Mixed-methods research will combine emissions modeling, field experiments, remote sensing, and socioeconomic analyses to assess trade-offs, co-benefits, incentives, and local adaptation of standard practices.

To assess and support carbon sequestration (HLO 4.1), spatial modeling, geographic information system (GIS), and socioeconomic analysis will identify high-potential landscapes and viable finance mechanisms (e.g., REDD+). Achieving and increasing methane reduction targets (HLO 4.2) will be supported by emissions analyses and co-benefit assessments, analyses of socio-technical systems and ex-ante policy and behavioral experiments to test incentives. Transition to low-emission food systems (HLO 4.3) will be explored by targeting key emission sources across the agri-food value chain. Through life-cycle assessments, innovation labs, and value chain analysis, we will explore innovations in circular and closed-loop systems, reduction of food loss and waste, local food systems, clean energy, and precision nutrient management. By partnering with governments, private-sector actors, and civil society, this work innovatively integrates technical, institutional, and policy dimensions to drive systemic shifts toward sustainable and equitable low-emission food systems. To improve monitoring (HLO 4.4), big-data platforms, AI-supported models, and user-friendly digital tools will enable transparent, low-cost MRV. Just transitions (HLO 4.5) will be supported through participatory co-design of solutions, ex-ante impact assessments and participatory policy design to increase the agency of women and youth in mitigation action.

AoW5: Finance and Policy for Scaling Solutions

AoW5 develops the evidence base to inform national policy, increase climate finance, and strengthen emerging institutions for scaling climate solutions. HLO 5.1 develops the evidence to inform NDCs 3.0, long-term, low-emission, climate-resilient development strategies (LT-LEDS), local adaptation plans for action (LAPAs), NAPs, and climate-related policies. It also generates evidence to strengthen national net zero and climate security strategies. These country-level analyses will be informed by and inform data harmonization and global analyses in HLO 1.3, integrate results from AoW3 and AoW4, and connect with communication and engagement in HLO 1.5.

HLOs 5.2 and 5.3 aim to increase climate finance for smallholder farmers and marginalized food system actors, recognizing the distinctive opportunities of public and private finance sources. HLO 5.2 uses data, analytical tools and frameworks to strengthen policymakers' capacities to design, access, and implement public-originating climate finance, including for countries in conflict. The goal is to increase the pipeline of funded climate projects. HLO 5.2 also tracks climate finance demand and flows. HLO 5.3 focuses on private sector finance and testing innovative models to unlock new sources of private capital, such as risk-contingent credit. While all HLOs have a strong equity and inclusion aim, HLO 5.3 prioritizes improving women's access to private climate finance, where gender barriers are particularly challenging. Both HLOs will include innovations for public-private blended finance as an increasingly necessary model for de-risking finance while also achieving impacts at scale.

HLO 5.4 will strengthen emerging institutions and ensure that they serve smallholder farmers in LMICs. It will achieve this by developing methodologies, including event attribution and other risk analytics, to generate localized loss and damage (L&D) evidence for agrifood systems, with a focus on vulnerable groups. HLO 5.5 will work with carbon market actors to design mechanisms that enhance equity in carbon markets by reducing transaction and MRV costs, leveraging advanced MRV systems (AoW4.4) and innovative financing strategies.

2. Codesign and partnerships

The Climate Action Program was fundamentally shaped by engagement with national institutions, science-policy interfaces, and innovation partners across all CGIAR regions. Throughout the design and inception period, the Climate Action Program prioritized structured co-design processes to inform deliverables under each AoW. Every engagement was anchored to a defined technical objective. This allowed partners' priorities, data, and analytical tools to shape work plans, performance indicators, and digital tool specifications at an early stage. These engagements generated hazard thresholds, business-case formats, policy-alignment guides, financial indicators, and data-architecture specifications that now appear in Climate Action deliverables and monitoring instruments.

The structure of each engagement aligned with the CGIAR Engagement Framework for Partnerships and Advocacy. The Program's co-design approach extends beyond the Portfolio Listening Sessions. During 2024, the Climate Impact Platform hosted virtual consultations with the CGIAR Climate Community of Practice to inform the design of the Program. During CGIAR Science Week in 2025, the Program hosted two events with partners and funders to share progress and gather feedback on the Program's direction. Furthermore, in 2025, initial Program inception meetings in Sri Lanka and India (Odisha and Tamil Nadu) provided key discussion spaces with national and local partners.

The Program's engagement is also driven by iterative engagement, local ownership, and distributed learning, and embedded in regional processes such as the Climate Action Platform for Agriculture in Latin America and the Caribbean (PLACA) and the African Group of Negotiators Expert Support (AGNES) in Africa. This model will continue into implementation through structured mechanisms: joint work planning with ministries, adaptive learning, and communities of practice aligned with national frameworks (e.g., NFCS, NAPs, LT-LEDS). Engagements were initiated only where local demand, CGIAR expertise, and operational feasibility intersect, reflecting the Framework's alignment criterion.

Below, we provide examples of recent or upcoming partner engagements and co-design activities.

- In South Asia, collaborative design of risk dashboards and early warning protocols in Sri Lanka and India directly informed AoW2 (Digital Advisories) and AoW5 (Finance and Policy).
- In Southeast Asia, the Program collaborated with innovation and scaling partners to enhance climate advisories and develop implementation guidelines for area-based yield index insurance in the Philippines (AoW2).
- In West Africa, climate-security indicators were co-developed and are now embedded within AoW3 (Locally-led Adaptation).
- In East and Southern Africa, investment-readiness formats co-created in Ethiopia, Kenya, and Zambia support AoW4 (Low-emission Transitions), and national spatial planning tools co-designed with partners through NEXUS Gains contribute to AoW1 (Prioritization and Coordination).
- In Latin America, the Program plans to participate in the General Assembly of PLACA along with 17 Ministries of Agriculture in July 2025. This builds on partner engagement within previous Initiatives, such as AgriLAC Resiliente.
- At the global level, the Program through the CGIAR Centers engaged in global discussions, both through Pre-COP and Pre-SB processes of the UNFCCC. Climate Action also collected inputs on support needs for the implementation of the Koronivia joint work on agriculture which now enters its implementation stage.

The Comparative Advantage analysis (Section 4, this report) highlights key partners for Climate Action. These are classified as follows:

- **Global technical and normative bodies** such as FAO, IPCC, and WMO provide essential guidance, standards, and global assessments, but are typically not mandated or equipped to deliver country-level implementation. Climate Action builds on their frameworks to develop actionable, nationally aligned tools.
- **Advanced research institutions (ARIs) and global data providers** (e.g., Potsdam Institute for Climate Impact Research, University of Leeds, Coordinated Regional Downscaling Experiment-CORDEX) bring cutting-edge modeling, global public datasets, and scenario expertise, often focused on specific components or academic research. Climate Action ensures these insights are translated into integrated, context-specific decision support systems.
- **Development NGOs and civil society actors** offer strong equity, justice, and grassroots perspectives but typically do not lead on systems modeling or climate analytics. Climate Action partners with them to embed inclusivity into risk tools and policy processes.
- **Private sector actors** innovate rapidly and bring scalable digital solutions but sometimes operate with limited public accountability or national alignment. The Program brokers partnerships to link their tools with public systems and safeguards.
- **National governments and regional organizations** are key demand partners, and serve as critical enablers for policy uptake, coordination, and public service delivery. Climate Action co-develops tools and plans with these stakeholders, strengthening institutional readiness, aligning with NDCs/NAPs, and embedding innovations into public systems.

A clear example of how this engagement strategy helps deliver Climate Action's goals relates to designing readiness activities with AGNES, the University of Leeds, and targeted countries. These activities provide: (i) technical support for countries to update and increase ambition in their climate policies; and (ii) capacity building for them to access finance for implementation. This collaborative work has also been catalyzed by country parties voicing their support for climate risk assessments and for no-regret adaptation and mitigation solutions for the upcoming NAP and NDC 3.0 submissions due in COP30.

Moving forward, public authorities, private firms, academic organizations, and civil-society actors will continue to shape the Program's technical content, implementation schedule, and accountability framework.

Climate Action will establish a Country Coordination mechanism to coordinate partnerships within the Program. The Country Coordination Mechanism will be co-led by CGIAR country representatives and national stakeholders. This mechanism will serve as a platform for harmonizing AoW activities, fostering synergies, avoiding duplication, and aligning interventions with national priorities and ongoing initiatives. This approach will also build on existing partner networks built and/or leveraged by CGIAR Initiatives such as ClimBeR, Mitigate+, NEXUS Gains, Livestock and Climate, the Climate Impact Platform and relevant bilateral projects to streamline delivery and scale innovations effectively. Climate Action will also provide opportunities for structured feedback from partners to assess co-design, partner satisfaction, and research uptake.

The Program's co-design and country coordination mechanisms are structured yet flexible to ensure that co-design and partner engagement remain an adaptive process. These mechanisms will improve responsiveness to partner needs and support adaptive management as needs evolve.

3. Theory of change and MELIA

The Climate Action Program's ToC and MELIA system aim to drive measurable contributions to the Paris Agreement and to support CGIAR-wide reporting and delivery under the Climate Change Impact Area. The Program specifically targets [foundational pillars of the Paris Agreement](#): (i) the Global Goal on Adaptation (Article 7.1), which calls for strengthened resilience, adaptive capacity, and reduced vulnerability; (ii) Article 2.1(c) and 6, which emphasize aligning financial flows with low-emission and climate-resilient development; (iii) Article 2.1(a), which commits to limiting global temperature rise through significant reductions in GHG emissions; (iv) Article 2b, which commits to balancing climate action with food security; and (v) Article 4, which calls for equity in mitigation action.

To support countries in achieving these goals, the Program is developing tools and methods to track the effectiveness of adaptation actions, quantify their interactions with emissions outcomes, and assess their influence on investment and policy decisions. These are critical intermediate outcomes on the pathway to system-level impact. In addition to tracking its own outputs and outcomes, the Program supports and plans to help coordinate other CGIAR Programs and Accelerators. It will do this by providing frameworks, tracking systems, and analytical methods that enhance their ability to report contributions to climate adaptation and mitigation across FLW systems. Continuous learning and evidence generation are embedded in the MELIA system, ensuring that science, capacity sharing, and innovation remain responsive, decision-focused, and aligned with both global and system-level expectations for impact at scale.

3.1 *Theory of change*

The Climate Action Program envisions coordinated and equitable climate action across FLW systems contributing to international and country goals on climate adaptation and mitigation. It leverages the learnings and achievements from CGIAR's Research Programs (CRPs) (e.g., Climate Change Agriculture, and Food Security (CCAFS); Forests, Trees, and Agroforestry (FTA)) and Portfolio 2022 Initiatives (e.g., ClimBeR, Mitigate+, NEXUS Gains, and the Impact Platform). It also advances CGIAR's climate research portfolio to deliver global, national, and local place-based solutions.

The ToC highlights the Program's integral role in coordinating and catalyzing inclusive climate action through impactful research and engagement to guide a just climate transition toward more resilient FLW systems. It is framed around holistic and reflective systems thinking, emphasizing the vital roles of stakeholders in creating feedback loops that accelerate the dissemination of knowledge and solutions to reach impacts at scale. These mechanisms strengthen the Program's alignment with and contribution to all CGIAR Impact Areas, with a strong emphasis on Climate Adaptation and Mitigation.

By 2030, the Program aims to achieve the following End-of-Portfolio outcomes: (1) Producers and other FLW system actors use climate adaptation or low-emissions solutions; (2) Public and private sector actors mobilize finance for just, low-emissions climate action and just transitions; (3) New climate/ sectoral policies are informed by climate data and evidence; and (4) Enabled systemic change in research approaches of public and civil society actors through strengthened institutional capacity for incorporating locally-led adaptation, low-emission solutions, and evidenced-based tracking of climate policies into the portfolio of climate change response. The latter outcome was added during the Inception Phase to capture capacity change outcomes across the Program.

Recognizing that the End-of-Portfolio outcomes fall under the sphere of influence beyond Program control, the Climate Action Program intentionally aims to inform public and private sector actors to

shape climate action. Intermediate outcomes are centered on improving the capacities of system actors to affect behavior or practice change that enables just and inclusive climate action supported by adequate and sustained climate investments. Anchoring on participatory approaches, the Program sees capacity sharing and strategic engagement with stakeholders at all levels as a vehicle for uptake of its outputs to influence evidence-based and data-driven climate policies, strategies, financing, and processes. These eventual outcomes are expected to emerge through strategic co-development, delivery, and scaling of HLOs.

The Program HLOs are grounded in co-producing tailored climate solutions including proven tools, frameworks, and methods that support just, low-emissions, locally led, and inclusive climate action. Central to co-production and stakeholder uptake of HLOs is the generation of accessible, synthesized, and inclusive (gender and social dimensions) climate data, knowledge, evidence, and insights. These insights foster collaborative, coordinated, and sustainable climate action within CGIAR and among external stakeholders.

To allow the outcomes and impacts to effectively emerge, the Program's assumptions consider external factors such as stakeholders' behavior and presence of conducive environments with adequate structural enablers. The Program assumes that stakeholders are: (1) interested in addressing climate-related issues; (2) willing to engage in participatory processes; (3) receptive to new tools, methods, and frameworks; and (4) take ownership of co-developed data, knowledge, tools, and solutions. Assumptions on structural enablers include the presence of incentives, complementary resources, and supportive policies and finance, among others.

The ToC has been revised by adding, merging, and reformulating results to improve the clarity and plausibility of intervention logic to better align with the CGIAR Results Framework and Impact Areas. The revision considered the feedback from the ISDC and donors, prioritization exercise, bilateral mapping, and recent internal implementation dynamics (e.g., budget reduction). Key changes in the ToC incorporate critical outcomes and HLOs needed to reach equitable impacts at scale along CGIAR impact pathways. These include: (1) emphasizing results on fostering collaboration for harmonized climate action within CGIAR and among external stakeholders; (2) intentional targeting of women, youth, and marginalized groups; (3) enabling systemic change through broader institutional capacity strengthening; (4) highlighting stakeholder uptake (access-use-adoption) of HLOs or climate solutions; and (5) highlighting the role of evidence, partnerships, and multi-stakeholder platforms in influencing social and behavioral outcomes.

Refer to the full [Climate Action ToC](#) for additional details.

3.2 Monitoring, Evaluation, Learning, and Impact Assessment (MELIA)

Climate Action has developed a robust MELIA Plan aligned with its updated ToC and the CGIAR Results Framework. The MELIA Plan outlines the approaches for adaptive management, accountability, and evidence generation across all AoWs and the Program in general.

Monitoring and Evaluation (MEL): HLOs and outcomes will be tracked through a harmonized Results Framework, with indicators aligned to CGIAR Impact Areas and 2030 targets. For the Climate Impact Area, key outcome indicators include: (i) number of people with increased resilience to climate change, (ii) volume of GHG emissions reduced or avoided, (iii) levels of climate finance mobilized; and (iv) number of climate-informed policies influenced. Data will be collected through rolling, system-integrated approaches that enable continuous monitoring, rapid feedback, and frequent quality checks. These systems blend digital tools, rapid interviews, and validation to ensure timely and reliable tracking of activities, outputs, and outcomes in line with ToCs and impact pathways for Program activities. The MEL strategy will enable the Program to track climate action

and uptake of solutions within and outside of CGIAR and determine contributions of various actors and programs to intended outcomes and targets.

Annual reflect–replan–adjust cycles, informed by performance reviews, will support adaptive management. Reviews will assess progress against work plans, gender and inclusion metrics, and partner engagement. At least two formal evaluation studies are planned—focused on science-policy uptake and capacity outcomes—coordinated by the MELIA team and aligned with CGIAR-wide evaluation policies. Lessons from past evaluations have informed revisions to indicators, responsibilities, and learning loops.

Impact Assessment (IA): Climate Action’s IA strategy focuses on high-potential interventions and key questions prioritized by partners and aligned with 2030 outcomes. Initial studies (2025) will examine: (i) the Role of Dialogue Platforms in Advancing Zero-Deforestation Supply Chains in Colombia, (ii) the use of Africa Agriculture Adaptation Atlas data by investors to inform USD 2 billion in investments; and (iii) estimating weather and climate information use by farmers in several countries. These studies will use experimental and quasi-experimental methods, and contribution analysis; and will be implemented in priority countries across Africa, Asia, and LAC. Selection is based on strategic relevance, feasibility, and demand from national and regional partners.

Of the 21 studies identified in the MELIA Plan, some will be implemented directly by AoW teams with guidance from the MELIA team so they are consistent with CGIAR indicators and methods. Some will receive support (in the design and other stages of their implementation) from the MELIA team, and others will be led by the MELIA team in collaboration with AoW leads. The studies will be implemented between 2025 and 2030, with most of them being implemented in 2027 and 2029. Several studies that started prior to the Program will be finished in 2026. The Program’s IA strategy includes implementing three causal impact assessment studies: six adoption studies, one tracing of scaling activities and policy advice study, and 11 qualitative outcome studies. Funding sources include: (i) the core Window 1 and Window 2 (W1/W2) MELIA budget (2026-2030); (ii) earmarked bilateral project funds; (iii) W1/W2 allocations to Centers; and (iv) co-financing from partners, including through CGIAR’s Standing Panel on Impact Assessment (SPIA) calls. While implementation is decentralized across AoWs, oversight and synthesis are centrally managed to ensure quality and comparability. Coordination with seven other Programs will support joint baselines and shared methods, as well as more efficient use of resources.

System-wide Learning and Engagement: Climate Action is actively shaping CGIAR’s evolving MELIA architecture. The Portfolio Performance Unit (PPU) is leading updates to impact area indicators, the Performance and Results Management System (PRMS), and reporting tools. Climate Action contributes through mapped bilateral projects like MELIA and Foresight (MELIAF) and Adaptation Insights (Gates Foundation), which serve as platforms to test and refine monitoring approaches for tracking CGIAR’s contributions to adaptation and mitigation.

Refer to the MELIA Plan and Results Framework attachments for additional details.

4. Comparative advantage analysis

Climate Action undertook a detailed comparative advantage assessment across all HLOs to evaluate CGIAR's positioning relative to other actors. The analysis identified 36 institutions that could undertake aspects of the Program's work. These were evaluated by geography, likelihood to deliver, and estimated efficiency and impact. Of the 24 HLOs analyzed, 12 (50%) were assessed as areas where at least another party is highly efficient and impactful, and nine were areas with moderately capable parties. In three HLOs (HLO 1.1, 4.1, and 4.2), CGIAR was found to be the single best-positioned actor, based on its unique integration of science, equity, and partnerships as well as its deep expertise in science-based low-emission development strategies. This analysis helped Climate Action identify when to lead, where to complement, and when to allow others to lead. The results will be used to inform plans and partnerships in 2026.

Under AoW1 (Coordination and Prioritization of Climate Action), CGIAR is strongly positioned to coordinate its own climate action agenda. However, it is moderately positioned in most HLOs, with strong comparative actors such as FAO, World Resources Institute (WRI), and several advanced research institutions (ARIs) operating at global policy levels. These institutions lead in standard setting, policy convening, and multilateral engagement. The Program will focus on strengthening partnerships with these organizations and supporting these processes with robust, context-rich evidence and analytics that reflect LMIC realities. The Program will also engage and mobilize in-country stakeholders and governments towards effective coordination of climate agendas.

For the four HLOs in AoW2 (Digital Advisories and Climate Risk Management), CGIAR is well-, or moderately well-positioned across the board. One HLO (multi-hazard early warning and anticipatory action) is dominated by operational agencies such as the World Food Programme (WFP), Red Cross, and Africa Risk Capacity (ARC), which are highly efficient in delivery. While CGIAR does not lead on operations, it contributes distinctive value in co-design, targeting, and impact evaluation. Therefore, the Program retains a focused research role. The remaining three HLOs within AoW2, namely, climate information services, water-climate resilience, and integrated strategies, fall into the moderate comparative advantage category. CGIAR's strength lies in integrating science, usability, and equity, often missing in the offerings of other actors. The Program's involvement here is justified by CGIAR's convening power and track record in systems-level innovation.

AoW3 (Locally-led Adaptation) and AoW4 (Low-emission Transitions) show mixed comparative landscapes. AoW3 includes both strongly and weakly positioned HLOs, but CGIAR's local presence, participatory methods, and credibility with national partners justify continued engagement. While partners such as World Vision International, Digital Green, CARE, and many local NGOs are active in the LLA space, CGIAR's expertise can complement these. CGIAR is well placed to bridge implementation with research and offers added value in designing, testing, and scaling LLA mechanisms in fragile or under-researched contexts. AoW4 is better positioned overall, with CGIAR bringing technical innovation and policy linkages to integrated mitigation pathways. CGIAR provides essential science-policy linkages and innovation design, especially in methane reduction, MRV systems (e.g., CGIAR is well positioned for generating primary data for emissions estimates), and landscape-level strategies. These comparative strengths justify continued direct engagement.

AoW5 (Finance and Policy for Scaling Solutions) had the highest number of HLOs where CGIAR was weakly positioned. Institutional actors such as the World Bank, the International Fund for Agricultural Development (IFAD), and several UN climate bodies (including FAO, UNDP, UNESCO, and WFP) are active in this space, but often in partnership with CGIAR, providing finance. Thus, while CGIAR is not operating alone in the climate policy and finance space, it does contribute

targeted methods and tools, such as for tracking equity in finance and operationalizing inclusive metrics. For instance, CGIAR's research adds granularity to global frameworks, making them applicable to LMIC food systems, including for climate finance access and L&D methodologies (HLO 5.4). Likewise, CGIAR will also provide technical assistance to International Finance Institution (IFI) investments and collaborate with UNFCCC and other organizations at the science-policy interface to support countries as they scale climate action and meet their NDC/NAP targets.

Refer to the Comparative Advantage attachment for additional detail.

5. Prioritization

5.1 Knowledge-driven priorities

The knowledge-based prioritization process identified priority HLOs and their geographies. The geographies were identified based on the results of the analysis and other factors, including climate vulnerability, GHG emissions reduction potential, institutional capacity levels, and stakeholder demand. The relevance of specific HLOs varied by region, but most HLOs were prioritized in ESA and SEA.

Table 1 summarizes Climate Action’s final prioritization decisions by geography and HLO in each of the five AoWs.

Refer to the Prioritization attachment for more information.

Table 1: Prioritization by HLO and geography

HLO	Priority by HLO (↑higher; ↓lower)	Priority regions	Additional Context
AoW1 Prioritization and Coordination of Climate Action (CGIAR Climate Hub)			
HLO 1.1 Global and regional partnerships that facilitate exchange and use of integrated knowledge for climate action and negotiation established	↑	Global	In HLO 1.1, training activities are deprioritized and activities focused on the Community of Practice and coordination are prioritized.
HLO 1.2 Frameworks, strategies and tools for vulnerability root causes, climate justice pathways	↑		In HLO 1.2, just transition frameworks for CGIAR are postponed.
HLO 1.3 Harmonized data, simulations, insights and decision support tools for understanding climate risks, emission hotspots, and trade-offs	↑		HLO 1.3 remains a priority given CGIAR and partner demand for harmonized and actionable climate data. In 2025 we will work on developing prototype methodologies and platforms that can be scaled up in 2026+ with additional funding.
HLO 1.4 Synthesis products, advocacy and communication materials	↑		HLO 1.4 (synthesizing climate insights) remains a priority for both CGIAR and partners.
HLO 1.5 Strategic engagements with global climate bodies	↑		In HLO 1.5, some communications activities will be shifted to the Program Management Unit (PMU) to prevent duplication.
AoW2 Digital Advisories and Climate Risk Management			
HLO 2.1 Climate information products and services	↑	ESA, SA, WCA (priorities across all AoW2 HLOs) CWANA, LAC, and SEA (prioritized where clear entry points exist)	HLOs 2.1 and 2.2 are given the highest priority for investment. Refer to the in-depth analysis for AoW2 (see Full AOW2 Prioritization Document).
HLO 2.2 Multi-hazard early warning and anticipatory action instruments	↑		
HLO 2.3 Inclusive multi-sectoral recommendations co-developed to strengthen water-climate resilience strategies	↓		HLO 2.3 will concentrate in SA.
HLO 2.4 Innovative and inclusive partnerships to deliver integrated climate risk management strategies/actions	↓		HLO 2.4 will be implemented in WCA and LAC.
AoW3 Locally-led Adaptation			
HLO 3.1 Institutional innovations and technical practices co-created through locally-led adaptation and participatory research	↑	ESA, SA, SEA	AoW3 will focus on synthesis and documentation of lessons learned in 2025.
HLO 3.2 Methodologies for implementing LLA	↑		Budget reductions were absorbed by reducing operational costs. This has unfortunately meant terminating agreements with some key partners and making equally hard decisions to narrow the geographical focus of this AoW’s work.
HLO 3.3 Guidelines on scaling and implementing climate solutions and processes	↑		
HLO 3.4 Framework and methods for addressing negative outcomes of adaptation	↑		

HLO 3.5 Recommendations on policies and institutions for addressing the root causes of inequality for equitable climate change adaptation	↑		
HLO 3.6 Systematic engagement for developing capacity for locally-led adaptation and mitigation	↑		
AoW4 Low-emission Transitions			
HLO 4.1 Evidence and partnerships to inform low-emission development strategies across farms, forests, grasslands, and coastal landscapes	↑	LAC, SEA, WCA	This regional prioritization does not preclude engagement in other regions but reflects a targeted, phased approach, starting where institutional readiness and strategic opportunity are most aligned.
HLO 4.2 Socio-technological and ecological bundles for reducing methane emissions	↑	ESA and LAC (livestock), SEA (rice)	In 2025, HLO 4.2 focuses on rice in SEA and livestock in ESA due to higher mitigation potential. AoW4 will hold off on activities related to aquacultural systems and not expand rice work to SA.
HLO 4.3 Evidence and partnerships to inform low-emission food systems strategies including closed-loop production systems, improved nitrogen-use efficiency (NUE), minimized food loss and waste, clean energy, and dietary shifts co-developed and tested with private, public, and civil society sector stakeholders	↑	Prioritizing countries with the highest mitigation potential that can synergize with stabilizing and improving food availability in climate vulnerable countries	Final decisions on countries will also consider synergies with bilateral investment opportunities, private sector engagement, and political momentum on sustainable food systems.
HLO 4.4 Tools and approaches for monitoring, reporting and verification (MRV)	↑	ESA, LAC, SEA, CWANA	Specific countries to be targeted based on international commitments, research capacity, and CGIAR presence.
HLO 4.5 Recommendations to increase women’s and youth’s agency for mitigation	↑	ESA, SEA, WCA	WCA is prioritized for initial engagement due to institutional momentum and opportunities to leverage bilateral projects. Over time, implementation may expand in ESA, SA, and SEA.
AoW5 Finance and Policy for Scaling Solutions			
HLO 5.1 Country-specific evidence and tools that support the design, tracking, and reporting of national climate policies	↑	ESA, SA, WCA (for informing policy and public sector finance)	CWANA region is deprioritized at this stage due to limited governance as well as limited current levels of engagement and project synergies with climate finance and policy activities.
HLO 5.2 Analytical tools/frameworks on climate finance	↑	ESA, LAC, SA, SEA (for mitigation, private sector)	AoW5 is reducing engagement in China and removing the activity on climate-responsive water policies due to the budget reduction.
HLO 5.3 Private sector climate finance models	↑		
HLO 5.4 Methodologies and evidence for L&D Fund	↓	N/A	Activities in HLOs 5.4 and 5.5 are reduced due to the budget reduction. The tools and methodologies developed have global significance.
HLO 5.5 Carbon market frameworks	↓	N/A	

CWANA – Central and West Asia and North Africa; ESA – East and Southern Africa; LAC – Latin America and the Caribbean; SA – South Asia; SEA – Southeast Asia and the Pacific; WCA – West and Central Africa

5.2 Final decisions on the Program/Accelerator's direction and design

The Program is maintaining all five AoWs. Grounded in the Program's ToC, the five AoWs provide a sequentially linked and mutually reinforcing framework necessary for transformative climate action across FLW systems. Each AoW plays a distinct role yet is interconnected with the others. By generating climate analytics and risk insights, AoW1 focuses on priority setting and identifying knowledge gaps to inform climate research agendas within the Program and across CGIAR and its partners. AoWs 2 through 4 build on the foundation of AoW1 to co-design, develop, and deliver climate adaptation and risk mitigation (AoW2 and AoW3) and low-emission (AoW4) solutions. AoW5 then researches enabling policy and finance mechanisms that can scale these innovations and institutionalize change (AoW5). The Program's unique value lies in this interconnectedness, and dropping any AoW will compromise coherence, reducing our ability for integrated delivery of innovation, capacity sharing, and policy impact.

The final prioritization decisions by HLO and geography are summarized in Table 1. The knowledge-driven prioritization results were one data-point to inform prioritization. However, AoWs deviated from the results due to other factors, including partner demand, resource availability, and the limitations of the prioritization method.

The knowledge-driven prioritization method aims to rank HLOs by evaluating their relevance across CGIAR impact areas and regions. The structure is systematic but significant methodological limitations call into question the rigor and interpretability of the results. While we suggest potential remedies for each issue below, a more holistic reassessment of the overall approach relative to its intended use needs to guide any revision of the methodology; incremental fixes may not yield meaningful improvements.

Units of analyses. The approach treats HLOs as discrete and independently impactful. In practice, many HLOs are inherently interdependent and are designed to function as part of broader intervention packages. Isolating them in scoring frameworks obscures synergies, penalizes enabling outputs, and risks prioritizing stand-alone activities that may not deliver meaningful outcomes without complementary investments. In addition, the use of regions as the spatial unit for prioritization is often misaligned with implementation realities. Climate Action often operates at other levels, including global, where international negotiations and financial instruments shape responses. The Program also operates at the national and sub-national levels, where decisions are made and partnerships are formed.

Recommendation: Allow for multiple levels of analysis, enabling prioritization at regional, national, or sub-national scales depending on the nature of the HLO or intervention. Where a single level must be selected, default to country-level analysis. This approach recognizes the diversity of operational realities across CGIAR Programs while improving the relevance and granularity of prioritization outputs.

Cognitive burden and expert judgment. The methodology relies extensively on expert elicitation to score and justify thousand(s) of HLO–data entries. This imposes a substantial cognitive load, requiring thematic and geographic expertise that few individuals possess. The scale of the task inevitably leads to scorer fatigue, inconsistency, and reliance on heuristics. In Climate Action's case, the scoring involves over 1,200 unique entries (720 scores = 24 HLOs x 5 impact areas x 6 regions + 480 justification = 24 HLOs x 5 impact areas x 4 justifications). When experts are assigned only subsets of HLOs to score (a necessity given constraints), the small crowd introduces variability in assumptions, baselines, and mental models. Further, there are structural incentives to score more favorably those HLOs that align with one's own AoW, where the expert feels more confident

or where future funding may be perceived to depend on higher ratings. These dynamics distort comparability and reduce the objectivity of the scoring process.

Recommendation: Improve scoring reliability by providing guidance to be used across Programs such as expanding the expert pool to capture diverse perspectives, conducting calibration sessions to align assumptions and scoring baselines, and triangulating scores across independent reviewers to enhance consistency. To reduce bias, avoid assigning experts solely to HLOs within their own work areas, as this creates incentives for inflated scoring and limits objectivity.

Indicator selection and misalignment. The framework uses indicators to estimate HLO contributions for the regions. However, some indicators are misaligned with their intended outcomes. For example, the indicator for GHG emissions is used as a proxy under climate adaptation introducing conceptual error. Additionally, indicators are used across multiple impact areas (e.g., GHG emissions across climate and environment), leading to correlation in final rankings.

Recommendation: Ensure that indicators are conceptually aligned with the intended impact area. Inappropriate proxies undermine the validity of results as the prioritization is based on value unrelated to the goals.

Weighting scheme drives results. The prioritization outcomes are significantly shaped by the weights introduced in Steps B and C, which effectively predetermine the structure of the results. These weights assigned to impact areas and regions impose decisions about what matters most. We conducted a sensitivity analysis of the scoring, and it suggests that modifying the underlying scores has limited influence on the final rankings. It is the weighting scheme that drives the prioritization. This raises concerns about whether the process is genuinely driven by expert judgements (scores) or primarily a function of methodological design determining weights.

The Climate Action Program deviated from the prioritization outcomes to prioritize additional regions, particularly in Sub-Saharan Africa, where climate action has significant potential for impact. Based on the prioritization outcomes, the weightings consistently prioritized LAC and SEA due to their high mitigation potential but ignores regions that should also be prioritized due to their climate vulnerability and adaptive capacity.

Recommendation: If possible, scenario testing with alternative weightings schemes could be used to assess the robustness of the results.

6. Alignment of W3 and bilaterally funded work

The Climate Action Program's W1/2-funded research establishes CGIAR's core scientific direction on adaptation and mitigation, delivering global public goods and systems innovations. W3 and bilateral projects—43 mapped as of 1 June 2025 representing over USD 44.96 million directly aligned to the Program in 2025—play a complementary role by driving use, scale, and local relevance. These span all five AoWs and are regionally distributed across all regions. These projects fulfill five core functions that strengthen the Program's impact pathway and ToC:

1. Act as innovation laboratories that co-develop methods which later inform CGIAR-wide frameworks. For example, REMET-Rice Project (USD 2.7M, IRRI, Shell India) develops crop models and practices to reduce methane emissions from rice (AoW4.1); GCAN-Gender, Climate Change and Nutrition Integration Initiative (USD 5.7M, IFPRI, BMGF) delivers metrics for gender-responsive climate finance (AoWs 1, 5); and Adaptation Insights (USD 2.4M, Alliance, BMGF) creates protocols to track adaptation effectiveness across public and private investments and inform CGIAR MELIA for the climate impact area (AoW5.1).
2. Evaluate innovations in diverse settings. The JET-AgriSOL project (USD 4.1M, CIAT, BMW/IKI) pilots inclusive agrivoltaics in Colombia while developing training and finance solutions. In India, the Indo-German Cooperation on Agrivoltaics (USD 4.8M, IWMI, GIZ, IKI) integrates solar and agriculture through national partnerships.
3. Scale proven CGIAR innovations. CSICAP-Climate-smart initiatives for climate-change adaptation and sustainability in prioritized agricultural production systems in Colombia (USD 99.9M, Colombia Ministry of Agriculture, GCF/CAF) will deploy climate-smart agriculture and digital services across 22 departments, reaching 200,000 people and reducing over 2 million tons CO₂e (AoWs 2.1, 4.1).
4. Enable policy action and institutional uptake. iSPARK-Innovation in sustainability, policy, adaptation and resilience in Kenya (USD 949K, Alliance, FCDO) is also embedding adaptation metrics into county-level agro-advisories in Kenya, creating stronger links between CGIAR tools and local policy processes (AoWs 1, 2).
5. Build institutional capacity. The Accelerating Impacts of CGIAR Climate Research in Africa (AICCRA) Additional Financing (USD 8.5M, Alliance, IDA) scales climate services across six African countries. Adaptation Atlas (USD 2.4M, Alliance, BMGF) increases use of climate data for investment planning (AoW5.2).

An informal review identified nearly 100 additional activities that CGIAR Centers consider aligned with CGIAR Climate Action. These would extend the Program's work into more than 50 additional countries and are supported by over 10s of additional funders. Regionally, they include 20 activities in WCA, 29 in ESA, 55 in Asia, three in LAC, and 29 with global or cross-regional scope. Partners include the McKnight Foundation, AGRA, ACIAR, J-PAL, the Syngenta Foundation, and many national governments.

Taken together, the formal and informal mappings show that bilaterally funded projects are complementary and central to realizing CGIAR's climate ambition. They co-develop new methods, ground innovations in diverse contexts, scale solutions, shape policies, and build capacity. The informal mapping also highlights considerable latent potential within CGIAR's broader portfolio for achieving the Program's objectives. Extending alignment to the full 100% of CGIAR Center and aligned research institutes (e.g., CIFOR-ICRAF) projects, and deepening strategic integration across funding sources, partners, and regions, offers a clear opportunity to enhance coherence, efficiency, and impact of CGIAR's climate portfolio.

7. Plan of Results and Budget

The Climate Action Program has an approved W1/W2 allocation of USD 12.72 MM in 2025. The Program's W1/W2 funds are complemented by USD 44.96 MM in W3/bilaterals in 2025. The Program is implemented by 12 participating CGIAR Centers and the Alliance as well as non-CGIAR partners. All AoWs are implemented across at least five CGIAR Centers, demonstrating the Program's integration of CGIAR's climate research.

AoW1 Prioritization and Coordination of Climate Action accounts for USD 2.54 MM or 20 percent of the 2025 budget. Participating CGIAR Centers in 2025 include the Alliance, ICARDA, ICRISAT, IFPRI, ILRI, and WorldFish.

AoW2 Digital Advisories and Climate Risk Management accounts for USD 1.92 MM, or 15 percent of the budget in 2025. Participating CGIAR Centers in 2025 include the Alliance, CIMMYT, ICARDA, ILRI, IRRI, IWMI, and WorldFish.

AoW3 Locally-led Adaptation accounts for USD 2.01 MM, or 16 percent of the budget in 2025. Its CGIAR partners include AfricaRice, the Alliance, CIMMYT, ICARDA, IFPRI, ILRI, IWMI, IRRI, and WorldFish.

AoW4 Low-emission Transitions is the AoW with the largest share of the budget at USD 3.27 MM (26 percent). The Alliance, CIMMYT, ICARDA, IFPRI, IITA, ILRI, IRRI, IWMI, and WorldFish are contributing to implementation of this AoW in 2025.

AoW5 Finance and Policy for Scaling Solutions accounts for USD 2.35 MM, or 18 percent of the budget. AoW5's allocation includes USD 1.47 MM in W2 contributions. The Alliance, ICARDA, IFPRI, IWMI, and WorldFish are contributing to this AoW in 2025.

Management costs are factored into the budgets for AoWs 1 through 5. The estimated costs for the Program's Leadership team and Program Management Unit (PMU) in 2025 is approximately USD 2.4 MM. Leadership and PMU roles are shared across nine Centers (AfricaRice, the Alliance, CIMMYT, ICARDA, IFPRI, ILRI, IRRI, IWMI, and WorldFish).

CGIAR Centers were encouraged to use the results of the comparative advantage analysis and prioritization to inform their resource allocation decisions by AoW and HLO in 2025. In 2026 and beyond, resource allocations will be informed by performance assessments and a new prioritization methodology to better align with the Theory of Change.

Refer to the PORB attachment for detailed information.

8. Cross-Portfolio linkages and geographic coordination

8.1 Cross-portfolio linkages

The CGIAR Climate Hub (housed in AoW1) is the backbone of cross-portfolio coordination for climate work. It strengthens the consistency, quality, and collective impact of climate research across CGIAR. Four core mechanisms support this: 1) joint ToC alignment and impact planning, 2) shared research activities among AoWs and other Programs, 3) harmonized climate data and amplification, and 4) delivery at scale including supporting a one stop shop for innovations and Climate Action solutions.

1. Joint ToC Alignment and Impact Planning. The Climate Hub will establish a *Climate Action Steering Group* that brings together science and MEL leads from *all* Programs. The group annually reviews planned activities, ToCs, and results to identify alignment opportunities and strengthen impact pathways, coordination, and reporting toward climate ambition. This supports system-wide learning and integration of climate outcomes into program logic and action (see #2).

2. Shared Research Activities Among AoWs and other Programs. Programs collaborate on shared research activities that improve the relevance, efficiency, and scientific rigor of CGIAR's climate-related work. For example, the Climate Action Program provides foundational inputs, such as downscaled climate projections (including the forthcoming CMIP7 ensemble), and crop-climate modelling tools. These inputs are directly integrated into the breeding pipelines of *Breeding for Tomorrow* (e.g., stress trait targeting), the research design of *Sustainable Farming* (e.g., climate-risk stratification for intervention testing), and the investment engagement of *S4I* (e.g., cost-effectiveness analysis). In turn, these Programs ground Climate Action's tools in real-world settings, offering validated adaptation and mitigation solutions that reflect diverse agroecological and socioeconomic contexts through collaborations, for example with *Multifunctional Landscapes* on Living Labs for locally-led adaptation and all other Programs. FAIR data generation and access is supported through the Digital Accelerator, such as digital twin approaches. This two-way collaboration ensures that climate science is both upstream and downstream, shaping priorities and designs across the Portfolio while drawing on implementation insights to refine tools and frameworks for broader system use. Joint products, such as harmonized, FAIR datasets, decision-support tools, and validation studies, become the core of CGIAR's consolidated climate offer, and the Hub helps make it accessible to partners (See #3).

3. Harmonized Climate Data and Amplification. The Climate Hub curates and delivers shared datasets, standards, and methods for climate risk, socio-economic vulnerability, GHG emissions, and other core metrics that underpin climate-related work across CGIAR. The gender accelerator is engaged to support following FAIR and GESYI aware data principles. By providing a common evidence base, the Hub reduces duplication, ensures methodological consistency, and enhances the credibility and comparability of results across Programs. In addition to improving internal alignment, the Hub also plays a key role in amplifying CGIAR's collective climate insights—synthesizing evidence across the Portfolio for use by diverse external audiences such as the UNFCCC, IFIs, and the global scientific community. Further, local governance and fit-for-context solutions are supported through FAIR data generation and access. This ensures that CGIAR research informs not only Program decisions but also shapes international policy dialogues, investment frameworks, and priority-setting processes.

4. Delivery at Scale. The Climate Action and S4I Programs form a strategic alliance to drive climate science into the hands of millions. Climate Action's delivery workstreams—on digital advisories (AoW2), locally-led adaptation (AoW3), and low-emission strategies (AOW4)—generate evidence and innovations that S4I translates into scaling pathways through business models, public-private partnerships, and regional scaling hubs. In parallel, AoW5 (climate finance and policy) aligns with

S4I's work on enabling environments and finance mechanisms in its AoWs 3 and 4, respectively, supporting governments to access adaptation and mitigation options and embed them in national development and investment plans. Jointly, the Programs identify leverage points where delivery and finance intersect with systems-level scaling. The two Programs are positioned to equip millions of producers with climate solutions, support national implementation of NDCs and NAPs, and unlock finance for resilience and low-emissions development.

8.2 Geographic Coordination

Geographic coordination is central to delivering coherent and efficient climate action across CGIAR's Programs. To strengthen this coordination, we will develop a geographic coordination tool that systematically maps what climate efforts are being done, by whom, where, and with which partners. This tool will reduce the barrier to understanding programmatic overlap and help prioritize opportunities for integration and efficiency. Building on this, we will deploy shared implementation mechanisms, such as co-financed staff, aligned work plans, and unified stakeholder engagement, in countries where alignment is strong and where joint delivery has potential to improve outcomes. For example, in several countries, teams already co-deliver climate-informed advisory services, MRV systems, and policy support. Furthermore, bilateral projects like AICCRA serve as operational bridges, linking Climate Action's technical content with S4I's delivery platforms and regional partnerships.

A specific example of geographic coordination is with S4I, which overlaps with Climate Action in 77% of countries, creating strong opportunities for joint delivery. In Guatemala, Zambia, The Philippines, and Kenya, Climate Action's digital advisories are linked to S4I's public-private scaling models and scaling pathways. Furthermore, in Kenya, collaboration with Multifunctional Landscapes anchors joint work in a living lab generating multi-scalar data. In Ethiopia, Sustainable Farming's emphasis on improving soil health and fertilizer advisories integrates with Climate Action's digital climate services work. These examples show how aligned operations enhance impact, efficiency, and relevance across CGIAR.

9. Risk management

The Program Leadership conducted a participatory risk management process that enabled identifying and scoring the Program's top five risks, along with developing various mitigation, prevention, and control measures to help manage and reduce their impact. Please find the Program's risk register below, which highlights the top five risks. *Please refer to the following [link](#) with the Program/Accelerator's full risk register. This link is open to ISDC colleagues and others will be granted access on request.*

#	Category	Title	Description	Current Risk Level	Target Risk Level	Actions /Controls to manage risks
1	Business continuity	Failure to mobilize sufficient climate finance for the Program's outcomes and research.	Reduced funding due to shifting donor priorities could affect funding for climate research and the effort to mobilize \$15 billion in new finance, which is critical for scaling climate solutions across 30 countries. This outcome depends on convincing public and private sector actors, including development finance institutions and carbon markets, to invest. Risks include weak investment cases that fail to demonstrate return on investment (ROI), misalignment with funder priorities, or intense competition for climate finance, which the proposal notes is a growing challenge. Delays or rejections in funding applications could limit the Program's ability to achieve its targets, particularly in resource-intensive areas like low-emission transitions and adaptation. Reduced total volume and preferred topics of funding result in the need to adjust the Theory of Change and reallocate resources. Some AoWs may be underfunded which might affect the integrity and vision of the Program.	25	15	(1) Create detailed, evidence-based investment proposals that highlight the financial viability, scalability, and measurable impact of climate solutions to attract investors (supports AoW 5: Finance and Policy); (2) Engage early with key funders (e.g., Green Climate Fund, World Bank) to align Program goals with their investment criteria and build long-term trust (leverages AoW 5 partnerships); (3) Use innovative approaches like public-private partnerships or carbon credits to diversify funding sources and reduce reliance on single streams, increasing financial resilience (enhances AoW 5's finance strategy).
2	Research innovation	Technological or Scalability Challenges in Low-Emission Innovations	Avoiding emissions of or sequestering 1 gigaton of CO ₂ e per year by 2030 hinges on the success of low-emission innovations (e.g., carbon removal, methane reduction) under AoW 4. Risks include technologies underperforming in real-world conditions, failing to scale across diverse agroecological zones, or encountering unforeseen environmental or social trade-offs. The proposal	25	12	(1) Implement small-scale trials in priority countries to validate the effectiveness and feasibility of innovations before large-scale deployment (supports AoW 4's innovation pipeline); (2) Establish real-time monitoring systems to track performance, identify issues early, and adjust approaches based on data and feedback (complements AoW 4's MRV systems); (3) Pursue a

			acknowledges the ambition of this target, and any shortfall could compromise the Program's mitigation impact, a key pillar of its climate action vision.			portfolio of low-emission technologies and practices to mitigate the risk of over-reliance on a single solution, ensuring adaptability across contexts (enhances AoW 4's resilience).
3	Scaling impact	Insufficient Influence on Policy-Making Processes	The goal of informing 100 new climate or sectoral policies relies on the Program's ability to integrate climate data and evidence into national and regional policy frameworks (e.g., NDCs, NAPs). Risks include political resistance, lack of capacity within governments to interpret or act on scientific evidence, or data that is not timely or relevant to policy needs. The proposal emphasizes collaboration with policymakers, but if engagement falters or evidence is not compelling, systemic changes required for large-scale impact may not materialize, undermining outcomes across all areas.	16	9	(1) Place Program staff within government agencies or policy think tanks to provide ongoing technical support and foster direct influence on decision-making (supports AoW 1 and AoW 5); (2) Produce concise, actionable policy briefs and tools that translate complex climate science into practical recommendations, addressing specific governmental priorities (aligns with AoW 5's policy focus); (3) Organize workshops and forums with policymakers, scientists, and community leaders to co-create policies, ensuring broad buy-in and relevance (enhances AoW 1's coordination role).
4	Research innovation	Inadequate Integration of Gender Equality and Social Inclusion (GESI) Leading to Inequitable Outcomes	The Program emphasizes GESI as fundamental to its success, aiming to ensure equitable benefits for women, youth, and marginalized groups across all outcomes. However, there is a risk that insufficient integration of GESI principles could result in solutions that exclude or even harm these groups, exacerbating inequalities and reducing overall impact. For example, if digital advisories (AoW 2) or finance mechanisms (AoW 5) are not accessible to women or remote communities, the Program may fail to reach its 16 million producer target equitably or achieve just transitions.	16	6	(1) Perform thorough assessments during the Inception Phase to identify specific needs and constraints of diverse social groups, integrating findings into Program design across all AoWs (supports Section 11: GESI); (2) Ensure active participation of women, youth, and marginalized communities in co-design and decision-making processes, providing equitable access to resources and benefits (aligns with AoW 3 and AoW 5); (3) Use gender- and socially disaggregated data to track progress on inclusion indicators, adjusting interventions to address disparities and ensure equity (complements MELIA); (4) Scale out the integration of GESI into climate action through the Climate Hub and its workstreams on just transition frameworks and the root causes of climate vulnerability.

5	Scaling impact	Low Adoption of Climate Solutions by Producers	The Program aims to benefit 16 million producers by enabling them to use climate adaptation or low-emission solutions. However, there is a significant risk that producers may not adopt these solutions due to barriers such as lack of access to technology (e.g., digital tools or equipment), financial constraints, distrust in the provided information, or solutions that are not tailored to local contexts. The proposal highlights the rapid scalability of digital climate risk management tools (e.g., AICCRA reaching 3 million people in three years), but notes that access alone does not guarantee behavior change. If producers fail to implement these solutions effectively, the Program's flagship outcome will be jeopardized.	12	12	(1) Co-design Solutions with Local Communities: Engage producers, including women and marginalized groups, in developing and testing of solutions to ensure they are culturally appropriate, practical, and meet specific local needs (aligned with AoW 3: Locally Led Adaptation); (2) Offer training programs, financial incentives (e.g., subsidies or microfinance), and access to resources like seeds or equipment to reduce barriers to adoption (supports AoW 2 and AoW 3); (3) Establish on-the-ground demonstration sites and leverage peer-to-peer learning networks to showcase the tangible benefits of climate solutions, enhancing producer confidence and uptake (complements AoW 2's digital advisories).
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10. Addressing feedback on select topics

This section builds on the [November 2024 preliminary Management Action Plan in response to ISDC’s reviews](#). The table below outlines how the Climate Action Program has addressed Portfolio-level feedback during the Inception Phase or plans to do so during implementation.

Concise summary of feedback	Details on how the Program has addressed or will address this feedback
Research questions are too generic and not localized.	Research questions reformulated into more actionable "how can" formats. They are now more localized, drawing on IPCC and CGIAR experience, with co-development of hypotheses. For example, “How can generative AI improve the delivery of climate advisories to smallholder farmers in Odisha and Tamil Nadu?”. Research that involves AI should be guided by responsible AI principles and governance to reduce the risks associated with data privacy, bias, and lack of transparency. Inception Phase includes partner co-development of research hypotheses.
Lack of clarity on adaptation vs mitigation balance.	AoW scopes were reviewed to better balance adaptation and mitigation. 2025 work plans now reflect reallocation of resources to ensure equitable emphasis on mitigation, including mitigation-related activities under AoW1, AoW3, and AoW5 besides core mitigation activities in AoW4.
Weakness in integrating local knowledge and social inclusion.	Social inclusion is now embedded in all AoWs, with metrics being developed via MELIA. Local/Indigenous knowledge is central to research co-creation, with sub-AoWs explicitly focused on vulnerable communities (e.g., AoW1.2, AoW3, and AoW5.2).
Theory of Change lacks specificity and assumptions are not well stated.	During the Inception Phase, we undertook a comprehensive revision of both the Program and Area of Work Theories of Change to address issues of specificity and clarity. The revised ToCs now explicitly integrate key assumptions and delineate coherent, aligned pathways across AoWs. These improvements are reflected in the updated Results Framework, which is directly aligned with the revised ToCs and their associated results statements. The Framework now includes indicators linked to specific outcomes and places greater emphasis on capacity outcomes that were previously underrepresented. This version enhances programmatic coherence by connecting research, innovation, and policy efforts with measurable progress toward 2030 outcomes, resilience building, and mitigation impact.
MELIA lacks mechanisms for adaptive management, governance, and transparency.	MELIA has been redesigned to include mixed methods, ex-ante baselines, participatory evaluation tools, and clear roles across governance levels. This aligns with Portfolio Performance Unit expectations. Monitoring data will be collected and reported regularly, through rolling, system-integrated approaches that will enable continuous monitoring, rapid feedback, and frequent quality checks. This will ensure timely and reliable tracking of activities, outputs, and outcomes in line with ToCs and impact pathways and, through annual reflect–replan–adjust cycles, informed by performance reviews, will support adaptive management. Data will be managed centrally and reported to PRMS (monitoring data) or published (e.g., survey data). The Program will conduct annual performance reviews.
Scaling and risk pathways are underdeveloped.	AoW-specific scaling strategies are being finalized. All AoWs are interdependent and use of digital advisories (AoW2) and innovative policy, finance, and institutions (AoW5) are specifically designed for scaling. Furthermore, we will work closely with other Program/Accelerators, S4I in particular, to co-design scaling pathways during implementation.

Inter-Program collaboration is unclear.	AoW1 is formalized as the CGIAR Climate Hub with responsibilities to coordinate climate action within the Program and across all Programs/Accelerators. Collaboration with other Programs/Accelerators is reflected in the ToC and in the Climate Coordination Working Group.
Need for greater clarity on capacity sharing and decolonial research.	A unified capacity-building strategy will be launched in 2025. South-South learning and local institutional partnerships are being prioritized. Decolonial practices will be embedded through geographic coordination, co-design and MELIA feedback loops.
Lack of information on how water systems are covered in the Portfolio.	Water systems are addressed under AoW2, which includes research on climate risk management tools for water governance and adaptation planning. Research will integrate hydrological modeling and data platforms to support National Adaptation Plans.
There is a lack of information on how climate mitigation is covered in the Portfolio.	AoW4 directly addresses mitigation through co-designing and scaling innovations & solutions for low-emission transitions. Besides AoW4, AoW1, 3 & 5 also include climate mitigation activities, such as identifying emissions and mitigation hotspots; co-developing locally-led, low-emission solutions; and scaling low-emission technologies through innovative policy, finance, and institutions.
There is a lack of information on how youth and social inclusion (that does not relate to gender) is covered in the Portfolio.	Social inclusion frameworks are being embedded across AoWs, with inclusion metrics under development in MELIA. There is a specific focus on youth inclusion in digital services (AoW2), locally-led approach (AoW3), and finance access (AoW5). For example, AoW3 explores “how can youth-led organizations in Kenya and Ethiopia design and scale locally appropriate adaptation solutions?”.

Appendix 1: Addressing specific feedback

Concise summary of feedback	Details on how the Program has addressed or will address this feedback
FCDO: Justify geographic targeting.	Target countries were prioritized based on climate vulnerability indices, national climate commitments, and potential for impact across CGIAR impact areas.
BMGF: Clarify private sector engagement and impact pathways.	While the role of private sector involvement has been emphasized across all AoWs, AoW5.3 and 5.5 now explicitly define how science outputs will enable investment via blended finance and carbon markets, including partnerships with IFC, GCF, and Rabobank. Impact pathways are mapped in the updated ToC.
ISDC: Clarify use of IPCC and CGIAR past research.	Each AoW has now aligned with IPCC AR6 and CGIAR legacy initiatives (e.g., CCAFS, AICCRA). A synthesis of lessons and data use is underway to inform 2025-2026 activities.
FCDO: Request for SMART indicators.	SMART indicators are being integrated into MELIA ToC and aligned with impact areas (adaptation, mitigation, social inclusion). Interim set of indicators to be published in Q3 2025.
ISDC: Highlight energy, forests, and cooling.	The final proposal now includes sub-AoWs on energy (4.3), forests (4.1), and cold chain innovations under AoW2. These topics are integrated into mitigation models and MRV efforts.
BMGF: Concerns on overlapping AoWs (AoW1 vs AoW5).	Functions of AoW1 and AoW5 were reviewed. AoW1 focuses on prioritization, knowledge synthesis, and coordination of climate action, while AoW5 focuses on innovative finance and policy as well as institutional mechanisms. Activities are non-overlapping and complementary.
ISDC: Address root causes of vulnerability.	All AoWs are interdependent in such a way that while AoW1 undertakes vulnerability mapping together with identifying root causes of vulnerability, all other AoWs (AoW2-AoW4) are designed to adapt their technologies to address the root causes of vulnerabilities identified in AoW1.
BMGF: Define what it means to benefit 50 million people.	The Program adopts outcome mapping and contribution analysis to track reach. 'Benefit' is defined by increased resilience, emission reductions, and enabling policies. Quantitative and qualitative data will validate impact.
BMGF: Strengthen gender transformative approach.	Gender metrics and budgeting integrated into AoW MELIA plans. Gender-transformative innovations will be tested and scaled in AoW1, AoW2, and AoW5 with specific targets for women's organizations and youth.
Pending ISDC: Codesign vs listening sessions.	In developing this Program, we engaged with national governments, regional bodies, and local communities, through CGIAR listening sessions, to ensure our research agenda aligns with geographic needs. During implementation, our focus is on co-designing with local organizations by prioritizing their demand, knowledge and experience, fostering ownership, relevance, and legitimacy.